# 14 December 2025 — The Light That Never Dims, *Parashas Vayigash* and חנוכה

*Content-based review · reviewer read the transcripts, summary, and finished write-up · 1 November 2026*

## 1.The Shiur in One Paragraph

A short guest *drashah* (about fourteen minutes) at Young Israel of Woodmere on the eve of *Chanukah*, which the speaker says he also gave in his own shul that morning. It opens with an eighty-five-year-old Holocaust survivor who no longer cries and who tells the speaker, in Yiddish, “you should cry.” It turns to *Parashas Vayigash*: *Yosef* is the only person called *ish matzliach*; of his three life-phases (light, power, darkness) the word is used only of the darkness, because of *vayehi Hashem ito* and the Name on his lips (*Rashi* and the *Midrash*), the source of our *im yirtzeh Hashem*. It then moves to the footage released that week of the six hostages lighting a *menorah* in a Gaza tunnel, Hersh’s remark about the picture of the *menorah* and the Nazi flag, the story of Rabbi Dr. Akiva Posner’s photograph in Kiel, and the closing point: success is knowing that God is with you wherever you are, and the light of *Klal Yisrael* will not go out.

## 2.Overall Fidelity

The finished write-up follows the order and the spirit of the talk and keeps its best material (the survivor, the three phases, the *Midrash*, the Posner photograph). Three sources were read: the bilingual Plaud transcript (clearest; it glosses each Hebrew word and is the authority on every disputed point below), the Sofer-style “Speaker 1” transcript (heavily

garbled: “Ongner,” “Talmudist,” “Gotham”), and the AI summary. **No Sofer .docx exists for this date. As in earlier weeks, the write-up inherited its errors from the summary**, which in several places departs from both transcripts (a verse from *Bereishis* instead of *Tehillim*, “Rosh Hashanah,” “*baruch Hashem*,” “1932/1933”), and the footnotes added unsupported detail. The flags below were corrected in the finished HTML in the same pass except where marked.

## 3.Content Flags — Misstatements and Overclaims

**Flag 1 — The survivor quotes *Tehillim* 116:8, not *Bereishis* 48:16.** The write-up has him recite לאך הגאל אתי מכל רע (“the angel who redeemed me from all evil”) and fn 1 says this is Yaakov’s blessing of Efraim and Menashe, “reinterpreted.” Plaud: “every time I recite *Hallel*, כי חלצת נפשי ממות את עיני מן …גה את רגלי מדחי you saved me, you extracted me from *mavet*, from the valley of the death, but you also took away my ability to cry, א”. עיני מן דמעה The Sofer text is garbled, and the summary invented the angel line and a note citing “*Tehillim* 137:16.” The speaker is also explicit that this is the verse he says in *Hallel*, which the angel verse is not. Corrected in the body and fn 1.

**Flag 2 — “On that *Rosh Hashanah*” is not in the recording.** The write-up has the survivor look up at the SS officer “on that ש השנה.” Plaud: “I looked at this SS officer, at this ע ימח שמו.” The Sofer transcript’s “this Rosh Hashanah” is the garbled ע, which the summary and the write-up took literally. Likewise: “beat him” is, in Plaud, “gave him a slap”; and the age and year (“ten-year-old kid, 8-year-old, I don’t remember… 1939, 1943, 1944”) were turned into a firm “ten… 1943 or 1944.” Corrected.

**Flag 3 — *Im yirtzeh Hashem*, not *baruch Hashem*.** The write-up says “We say ך השם all day long” and ends “success… means השם on your lips.” Plaud is explicit and repeated: “we as Jews we say, בעזרת ,אם ירצה ה׳ , all day… if you say ירצה ה׳,” and the close, “success in Jewish terminology… is בעזרת השם ,ירצה השם.” The summary substituted “*baruch Hashem*” and “ה׳ ”; the write-up followed. Corrected in three places and

in fn 3 (“thank You, Hashem” is kept; the speaker says it as well).

**Flag 4 — “Ten months after October 7” belongs to the killing, not the lighting.** The write-up: “This was two כות ago, about ten months after October 7. We now know they were shot… around August 2024.” (the summary has the same conflation). Plaud: “This is eighty days into captivity. This is two כות ago… they were shot to death… I think August 2024, approximately eight, ten months after… October 7th.” Press reports agree on about eighty days. As written, the lighting and the murder were both ten months in, which cannot be. Corrected (and see Q3: the calendar count for *Chanukah* 2023 is about sixty-two days).

**Flag 5 — Hersh’s remark is longer and different.** The write-up has אתם ים את התמונה? (“Do you remember the picture?”). Plaud: אתם יודעים אתם רים את התמונה הזאת עם הדגל הנאצי והמנורה הנגדית. The summary שמע ישראל? shortened and altered it. Corrected, with the English rendered more fully.

**Flag 6 — The framing of the lead and the opening is the editor’s.** The lead says “This week’s drasha is short and not on our usual *sugya* of ת”לה and the opening says the encounter “transformed my understanding of what כה really means,” and ends “a new understanding of what כה is about.” None is in the recording. Plaud: this is a guest talk (“Thank you Rabbi [Axelrod] for inviting me… I have to make an apology, I’m going to share something very brief… Thank you, beautiful Young Israel of Woodmere”), and the encounter gave him “a whole new understanding of what *kind of people* we’re talking about.” Corrected in the lead and the body; the lead now says guest *drashah* at Young Israel of Woodmere.

**Flag 7 — The Posner photograph: year and the “original German.”** The body has the inscription dated “1932/1933” (the summary’s “כה תרצ״ג”); the speaker says “Chanukah 1932 (I think it was 1932, by 1933 he had already left for the Holy Land)”. Fn 5 supplies a “German original” (“Chanukah, 5694 / ‘Tod dem Juda’…”), a lifespan (1890–1962), and an “eighth night” with “preserved at Yad Vashem,” none from the shiur and none found in the sources. (5694 is 1933–34 and contradicts the body.) Replaced in fn 5 with what Yad Vashem and press reports support, and the year flagged as unsettled (see Section 5).

**Flag 8 — Fn 4: "preserved in IDF and family-released archives."** Not in the shiur. The footage was broadcast on 11 December 2025 on Channel 12's *Uvda* after the IDF obtained it from Gaza (Times of Israel). Corrected.

**Flag 9 — Fn 2 and fn 3: citation precision.** Fn 2's third quotation (39:23) opened "*vayehi Hashem es Yosef*…", which is 39:21; 39:23 reads …ואשר הוא ה׳ מצליח. Only 39:2 has *ish matzliach*; the other two have God as the one who makes succeed. Fn 3 cited "*Bereishis Rabbah* … ה׳ " (garbled for 86:5, which has the whispering but not the wording about the Name; that is *Rashi*'s, citing *Tanchuma Vayeshev* 8). Corrected.

## 4.Content Flags — Omissions

Said in the shiur and left out of the write-up. Item 1 is a substantive piece of the talk.

- **The exhortation to watch the clip.** "It is a *mitzvah* for every Jew to watch the clip. I told my shul, if you did not watch it, watch it; let the kids watch; it will enhance your *Chanukah*; when you light you will feel part of their lighting, part of their fulfillment of the will of the *Ribbono shel Olam*." (Restored in the Sefer Edition.)
- That the footage was released "this past week"; "the beautiful six"; the prayer *Hashem yikom damam*; that they sing *Maoz Tzur* and *Haneiros Halalu*; "eighty days" (see Flag 4).
- The Yosef details: the *kesones passim*; "from thirty until one hundred and ten when he dies"; "prime minister of Egypt"; that *Rashi* quotes only one line of a longer *Midrash*; the speaker's aside on the "bathroom" and horses and sheep.
- The Yiddish: the diminutive he was called, "Srolche"; *Farvos veinst du?*; *Aber du darfst veinen*.
- That Rabbi Posner left for *Eretz Yisrael* by 1933 and survived ("he saw the writing on the wall"); *Am Yisrael chai* and *Netzach Yisrael lo*

*yeshaker*; “we do not need stories from the Holocaust any more… Auschwitz, they lit the menorah, *mehadrin min hamehadrin*, we need that, but we have something closer.”

- The guest-speaker frame: thanks to the hosts, the apology, the joke (“Look down at your feet”), the closing “*a freilichen Chanukah*.”

## 5.Added or Editorial Material Not in the Shiur

- **“Fulfilling the *mitzvah* of *pirsumei nisa*”** (Section III) is in the summary only. The Sofer text has an unclear “the mitzvah of rochus”; Plaud does not have it. Plausibly what was said; kept, hedged in the Sefer Edition (Q2).
- **Fn 3’s** “develops this as the secret of success… constant *dibuk*”: editorial; narrowed.
- **Fn 5’s** dates, location and German, and the claim of an “eighth night”: see Flag 7. The sources consulted (Yad Vashem, Snopes) disagree on the year (1931 or 1932) and do not give the night or confirm that the building opposite was the Nazi headquarters; the speaker’s “*Zos Chanukah*, a Friday night” is therefore reported as his.
- **Fn 4’s** names of the six and the Rafah location are correct per press reports (Times of Israel, 29 August 2024), though not in the shiur.

## 6.Halachic / Lomdish Observations

- **“Three times *ish matzliach*.”** Checked on Sefaria: Genesis 39:2 (“a successful man”), 39:3 and 39:23 (God lent success). Only the first is the phrase; the speaker’s claim that no one else is called *ish matzliach* is accurate for the phrase. (Eliezer’s “*hitzliach Hashem darko*” in *Bereishis* 24 uses the root of another person, so the exclusivity belongs to the phrase and not the root.)

- ***Rashi* and the *Midrash*.** Confirmed: *Rashi* on 39:3 quotes *Tanchuma Vayeshev* 8, which has the whispering, the suspicion, and Yosef's answer that he was praying for favor. *Bereishis Rabbah* 86:5 has the whispering only. The "abracadabra" and the link to *im yirtzeh Hashem* are the speaker's.
- **The survivor's verse.** *Tehillim* 116:8 in *Hallel* is a verse of thanks: "my eyes from tears." The survivor takes it as the price of survival. The reading is his, and is the emotional center of the talk.

## 7.Follow-up Questions Worth Asking the Rav

Q1.Which survivor and when? (Approximate age and year; the line about men going "up in flames" that Plaud renders with *Tisha B'Av*.)

Q2.Did you say the hostages fulfilled the *mitzvah* of *pirsumei nisa*?

Q3."Eighty days into captivity": the calendar count to *Chanukah* 2023 is about sixty-two days. What did you intend?

Q4.The Kiel photograph: the year (1931 or 1932), the night, and the Nazi headquarters across the street—what is your source?

Q5."Tomorrow night": the first night of *Chanukah* 5786 was the evening of 14 December itself. Was the talk delivered earlier, or did you mean a later night?

Q6.Did you mean "three times *ish matzliach*" or the three uses of *matzliach*?

Q7.The closing words ("reciting *Hashem Melech*"?) and the names of the hosts (Axelrod, Hackenbroch, Schorr).

## 8.Bottom Line

*A faithful, well-shaped write-up of a short, moving talk. Its misstatements came, as before, through the summary (the wrong verse, Rosh*

> *Hashanah, baruch Hashem, the lead and the year), plus an unsupported apparatus of dates and a German text in fn 5. Fix those, restore the call to watch the clip, and separate what the speaker said of Kiel from what the sources give, and the sefer edition can stand. The most important correction is the first: the survivor's verse is Tehillim 116:8, and its "my eyes from tears" is the heart of the opening.*

Produced by a content-based review pass reading the Plaud transcript, the Sofer-style transcript, the AI summary, and the finished write-up (as delivered, before the corrections described above were applied). No Sofer .docx was present for this date.